Lab: You Are the One Who Notices

Objective

Explore the embodied sense of agency through somatic exercises that reveal the felt difference between voluntary and involuntary processes, between acting and being acted upon. This lab grounds the concept of the Active Inference agent in first-person bodily experience.

Prerequisites

- A quiet, comfortable space for 25 minutes
- Ability to stand and move gently
- No prior knowledge required

Part 1: The Witness Position (5 minutes)

Sit comfortably with your eyes closed. For the next five minutes, do nothing deliberately. Simply notice what your body does on its own: the breath moves, the heart beats, muscles make micro-adjustments to maintain posture, the belly gurgles, eyelids twitch.

You are not doing any of this. And yet, you are the one who notices it. This is the minimal self -- the pre-reflective sense of being a subject of experience, what Gallagher calls the experiential foundation of agency.

Write your response here

(List five things your body did without your deliberate intention. What was the quality of noticing them?)

Part 2: The Spectrum of Agency (5 minutes)

Now explore the gradient between involuntary and voluntary:

1. **Fully involuntary**: Notice your heartbeat. Can you speed it up by will alone? (Most people cannot.)
2. **Semi-voluntary**: Notice your breath. You can control it, but it also runs on its own. Breathe deliberately for 30 seconds, then let go and observe it return to autonomy.
3. **Fully voluntary**: Raise your right hand slowly. Notice the moment of intention -- the felt impulse before the movement begins. Lower it. Raise the left.

In Active Inference, all of these processes involve minimizing free energy. The difference is in which level of the generative model is issuing the predictions.

Write your response here

(Describe the felt difference between involuntary, semi-voluntary, and voluntary processes. Where in your body did you sense the shift?)

Part 3: Intention Before Movement (7 minutes)

Stand up slowly. Before each of the following movements, pause and notice the felt intention -- the body's readiness to move before it actually moves:

1. Intend to take a step forward, but do not step. Hold the intention. What does it feel like?
2. Now take the step. Notice: how does the felt quality change from intention to execution?
3. Intend to raise your arm. Hold. Notice. Then raise it.
4. Intend to turn your head to the right. Hold. Notice. Then turn.
5. Intend to sit back down. Hold the intention for five seconds. Then sit.

This pre-movement intention is what Active Inference describes as the generation of a motor prediction -- the body's model of what will happen next, before it acts to make it so.

Write your response here

(What did the intention feel like before movement? Was it in a specific location? How did it change when you actually moved?)

Part 4: Acting and Being Acted Upon (5 minutes)

Explore the difference between active and passive touch:

1. **Active touch**: Reach out and slowly explore the surface of a nearby object with your fingertips. Notice: you are the agent, the explorer, the one who moves.
2. **Passive touch**: Place your hand palm-up on your knee. With your other hand, gently touch and stroke the resting palm. Notice the difference in the resting hand -- it is being touched, being acted upon.
3. Switch which hand is active and which is passive. Notice how the felt quality reverses.

In Active Inference, active touch generates sensorimotor predictions (I expect to feel X when I move my fingers like this). Passive touch generates perceptual predictions (something is touching me, and I predict what will come next).

Write your response here

(Describe the felt difference between being the toucher and being touched. How does agency change the quality of sensation?)

Part 5: Reflection

Write your response here

(What is an agent? After this lab, how would you describe what it means to be an embodied agent in your own words?)

Reflection Table

Dimension of Agency	What I Felt	Active Inference Connection
Witnessing (minimal self)	______________	Pre-reflective self-model
Involuntary processes	______________	Autonomic free energy minimization
Pre-movement intention	______________	Motor predictions before action
Active touch	______________	Sensorimotor prediction generation
Passive touch	______________	Perceptual prediction and surprise